

GOPAL ITALIA, 33 (AAP): The party's state convenor came to prominence during the Patidar agitation in 2017. Has fire in the belly, but can be impulsive and brash



JAGDISH THAKOR, 65 (CONGRESS): The state president is an old warhorse. Grounded but lacks popular connect. Thakors are the largest OBC community, with influence in around 30 seats in north Gujarat



JIGNESH MEVANI, 41 (CONGRESS): The Dalit leader faces a tough contest in the Vadgam seat in north Gujarat. Expected to draw Dalit and Muslim votes in party strongholds

has declared candidates for about 80 seats and, as expected, most of them are greenhorns and a few are small-time Congress turncoats. Its state convenor Gopal Italia, 33, is AAP's most striking face in Gujarat. A former constable, he made a name for himself during the 2017 Patidar agitation and once made news for throwing a shoe at then home minister Pradipsinh Jadeja. Italia joined AAP in 2020 and could be a magnet for the Patidar youth. Often impulsive, his antics do backfire at times, as they recently did when he used "unparliamentary language" for PM Modi's mother.

The other known face, general secretary Isudan Gadhvi, is an untested OBC leader and ex-TV anchor known for his oratory. Rajya Sabha MP from Punjab Raghav Chadha, who is in charge of Gujarat, spends at least three days a week covering every corner of the state. Meanwhile, the BJP has taken the attack to AAP over Sisodia's alleged involvement in Delhi's 'liquor scam', although the latter dismisses this as a witch-hunt provoked by the saffron party's fear that it may lose in Gujarat.

THE 'SILENT' HAND

The Congress campaign in Gujarat has remained muted till now. In 2017, it was led from the front by Rahul Gandhi with the narrative a blend of soft Hindutva and an expose of BJP's *vikaas* spiel. This time, Rahul is busy with the Bharat Jodo Yatra which, surprisingly, is not even covering the poll-bound state. However, Rajasthan CM Ashok Gehlot, who played a key role in the party's performance in 2017, is back as observer. Senior leaders from other states have also been assigned seatwise responsibility to iron out local issues. The Congress will miss Ahmed Patel, the party stalwart who used to be the political secretary of Sonia Gandhi.

The party retains a strong organisation in the state, breeding optimism among party workers, as is evident from the number of ticket-seekers. In fact, candidate selection will play a crucial role in the poll outcome. The centralised selection process, on the whims of the high command, has often played spoilsport, leading to a large number of defections. The party seems to be taking the issue seriously as the first agenda of newly elected Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge is reportedly to finalise the candidates' list. He will also have to take a call on old-timers such as Shankersinh Vaghela, who want to return to the Congress fold.

The grand old party is building its campaign around inflation, unemployment, corruption in the BJP governments at the Centre and state, and invoking the growth of "Adani-Ambani by auctioning the nation's assets". Much like AAP, it has come up with several mega promises such as waivers of farm loans up to Rs 3 lakh and government jobs to nearly 1.5 million youths working on contract or as outsourced staff in state-run entities and departments. It's also banking on the community support of its Gujarat leadership. State president Jagdish Thakor is an OBC from the dominant Thakor community, leader of the Opposition in the assembly Sukhram Rathva is a tribal leader (the STs account for 15 per cent of the electorate) and Jignesh Mevani has emerged as a most prominent Dalit leader (though critics say he will have his hands full defending his own Vadgam seat).

After Hardik's exit, former leader of the Opposition Paresh Dhanani is their best Patidar bet. He is influential among the Leuva Patels in Saurashtra, though not across the state. Old-timer Siddharth Patel, son of ex-CM Chimanbhai Patel, is still in the game, but is not a statewide leader either. The Congress's best bet for swinging the Patidar votes in its favour was the exceptionally popular Naresh Patel, who almost joined the party earlier this year. His recent reported proximity with the BJP is cause for worry.

The party is confident of the Muslim vote, though, and has already been making noises on the release of convicts in the Bilkis Bano case. "We are not seeing it as a matter of religion, but as that of a woman's dignity and safety. There may be consequences with the BJP communalising it, but we will not shy away on this," says a Congress source. While that may or may not earn some traction among women voters, the emergence of players such as the AIMIM may dent Congress prospects in Muslim-dominated seats, particularly in those where victory margins were slim.

Beyond the hyped narratives and promises of each party, such ground dynamics will eventually determine the outcome of the Gujarat assembly election. For the first time since 1990, when the Janata Dal was pitted against the Congress and the BJP, the state will witness a serious triangular contest. The BJP has remained unbeaten since 1998 in a bipolar contest. Will the third player end that run or will it make the return to power easier for the saffron party? All three parties will be eager to find the answer to this mystery. ■